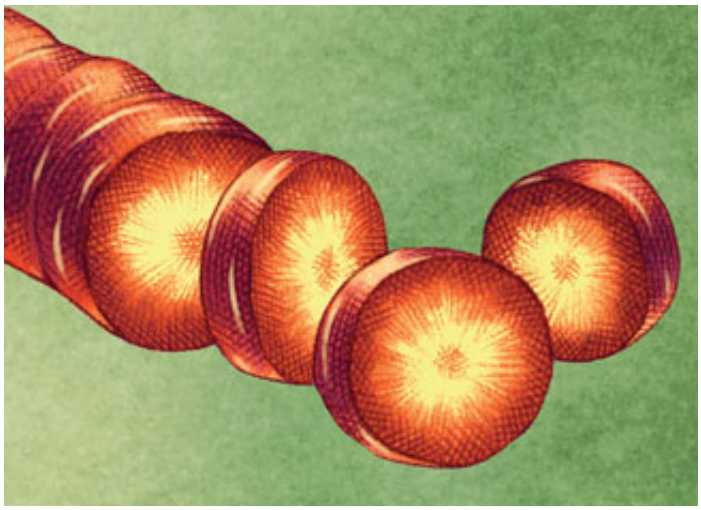
Learn How to Grow Carrots

Learn how to grow carrots with this helpful guide. Sweet, delicate carrots that can't be found in supermarkets are among a home gardener's greatest culinary rewards. By growing varieties suited to your soil, you can grow carrots in spring and fall, and the fall carrots can be left in the ground for harvesting in early winter. Includes tips on saving seeds for your next harvest, and pest and disease prevention tips.
August/September 2008
http://www.motherearthnews.com/organic-gardening/learn-how-to-grow-carrots-zmaz08aszgoe.aspx
By Barbara Pleasant



When cooking carrots, simply grill until tender or chop up and add to soups and stir fries.

Illustration by Keith Ward

Learn how to grow carrots. Choosing to grow crisp, delicious carrots of unique varieties in spring and fall can lead to great nutritious eating right from your backyard. Find out how to grow several varieties such as nantes, chantenay, imperator, miniature and danvers in your garden at home. By knowing the basics of when and how to plant, you can produce a successful harvest and have enough carrots to store throughout the year.

Learn How to Grow Carrots

(*For details on growing many other vegetables and fruits, visit our* Crop at a Glance

collection page.)

Types of Carrots to Try

Nantes are fast and easy to grow, and adapt to a range of climates and soils.
Chantenay carrots develop stocky roots that become sweeter as the soil cools in the fall.
Miniature carrots have small, shallow roots that are often quite sweet. They're good for heavy clay soil.
Imperator carrots are *long* and need deep, sandy soil to thrive.
Danvers carrots make great juice, and the sturdy roots store well, too.

For more details, see our chart *with descriptions of each type, cultural tips and varieties*.

Learn When to Plant Carrots

In the spring, sow carrot seeds in fertile, well-worked soil about two weeks before your last frost date. In cool climates, continue planting every three weeks until midsummer.

In summer, begin sowing seeds for fall and winter carrots 10 to 12 weeks before your average first fall frost. (To find your frost dates, click here and search for "frost dates.") Many gardeners plant carrots after their spring peas are finished.

Learn How to Grow Carrots

Prepare the planting bed by loosening the soil to at least 12 inches deep. Thoroughly mix in a 1-inch layer of mature compost or a half-inch layer of vermicompost (carrots love what earthworms leave behind).

Sow your seeds about a quarter inch deep and 2 inches apart, in rows spaced at least 10 inches apart; carrots do well in double or triple rows. Thin seedlings to 4 to 6 inches apart, depending on the variety's mature size.

Harvesting and Storage Carrots

Pull or dig spring-sown carrots when roots reach mature size and show rich color. Taste improves as carrots mature, but do not leave mature carrots in warm soil any longer than necessary (many critters like carrots). Summer-sown carrots that mature in cool fall soil can be left in the ground longer, but should be dug before the ground freezes to preserve their quality. Remove tops to prevent moisture loss, rinse clean, and store in a refrigerator or cold root cellar. Most varieties keep for several months in the fridge. Carrots also may be canned, pickled, dried or frozen.

Saving Carrot Seeds

Carrots are biennial and therefore won't flower and make seed until their second year. In cold climates, open-pollinated carrots kept in cold storage through winter can be replanted in early spring for seed production purposes. When the seed clusters have ripened to brown, collect them in a paper bag. Then allow them to dry for another week indoors before crushing the clusters and gathering the seeds. Discard the smallest seeds. Store the largest seeds in a cool, dry place for up to three years.

Carrot Pest and Disease Prevention Tips

Aster leafhoppers look like one-eighth-inch green slivers, which hop about when the foliage is disturbed. Leafhopper feeding causes light damage, but leafhoppers can spread aster yellows, a disease caused by a tumor-forming bacterium sometimes present in otherwise healthy soils. Trying to eliminate it would be unwise because of its close family ties with nitrogen-fixing rhizobia that benefit legumes. Instead, grow carrots in compost-enriched soil far from grapes and nut or fruit trees, which often host the parasitic bacteria. Use row covers to exclude the leafhoppers.

Row covers also protect a crop from carrot rust flies and carrot weevils, which make grooves and tunnels in carrots as they feed.

Hairy or misshapen roots can be caused by excessive nitrogen or aster yellows disease.

Carrot Growing Tips

Keep the soil moist for at least 10 consecutive days after sowing, because carrots take longer to germinate than other vegetables. To reduce surface evaporation during

the germination period, cover newly seeded soil with boards or old blankets for five to six days. Check daily, and remove the covers as soon as the first seeds germinate. Seeds germinate best when soil temperatures range between 60 and 70 degrees Fahrenheit.

Reduce weed competition by sowing carrot seeds in shallow furrows filled with weed-free potting soil. Cover the ground between rows with newspapers topped by a mulch of grass clippings.

Sow carrots with a "nurse crop" of radishes. The fast-growing radishes will shelter tiny carrot seedlings while helping to suppress weeds.

Be stingy with nitrogen. Among fertilizers, carrots favor compost or vermicompost worked into the soil prior to planting; they respond to abundant phosphorous and potassium more than to high nitrogen levels. Carrots take up nutrients best in soil with a pH between 5.8 and 7.0. Use lime to raise the pH of acidic soil.

Harvest carefully. Before pulling carrots, use a digging fork to loosen the soil just outside the row.

Harvest small blossom clusters from overwintered plants to use as cut flowers. Thinning the blossoms helps the plants channel energy to the biggest seed-bearing umbels (flower clusters springing from the same point).

Max out the season. To eat carrots year round, grow fast-maturing varieties in spring, and make summer sowings for a season-stretching fall crop.

Use soaker hoses or drip irrigation lines to keep the soil constantly moist.

Cover the shoulders of all maturing carrots with mulch to keep them from turning green.

For more in-depth information about growing carrots, read Growing Carrots: Carrot Varieties, Soil Conditions and Harvest Times.

Carrots in the Kitchen

Carrots will caramelize with their own sugars when braised in a little oil or grilled until tender. Grate raw carrots into muffins, cakes or pancakes to provide moisture

and extra vitamin A. Use carrots generously to bring nutritious color to salads, stir-fries and soups. Try steamed carrots with fresh mint and a dab of honey or brown sugar. Orange and yellow carrots are great as nutritious raw snacks, but red carrots taste best cooked.

Contributing editor Barbara Pleasant *gardens in southwest Virginia, where she grows vegetables, herbs, fruits, flowers and a few lucky chickens. Contact Barbara by visiting* her website *or finding her on* Google+.